

Muhammad Waqas Durrani

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PRINCE2 | CISA | Scrum Master (SFC) | Lead Auditor (ISO 27001) | GRC Professional | British Citizen | DBS Approved | Full UK Driving Licence.

Specializing in Digital & Application Management (SDLC) | PM/PMO | Data Centre Operations | Disaster Recovery | BAU | & Delivery Management.
Results-driven Infrastructure Project Manager, bringing 20 years of hands-on experience across sectors such as Financial Services, Retail, Insurance, and IT, I excel in project management, infrastructure leadership, and application development, adept at problem-solving for operational efficiency. I oversee project operations, enforce standards, mitigate risks, and execute dynamic work plans to maintain scope adherence and efficiency. With a Can-Do attitude, I execute solutions efficiently, streamline operations, and upgrade infrastructure across diverse platforms, collaborating with multi-functional units globally.

KEY SKILLS

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| • Project Leadership Project Reporting | • Stakeholder Management | • Coaching and Mentoring | • Risk Management (RAID) |
| • Project Discovery-Closure BAU | • Change Management | • Communication Management | • Delivery Logistic Management |
| • Conflict Management Problem Solver | • Asset Management | • Vendor 3 rd Party Management | • Cross-Function Leadership |
| • Mobile & Web App Development | • Waterfall Agile Hybrid | • Data Centre Operations & Projects | • ITIL & ITSCM Framework |
| • Infrastructure Leadership | • Server Hardware Break-Fix | • Disaster Recovery Plan & Testing | • DR Walkthrough Schedules |
| • Team Management in-Shore/off-Shore | • Flexible Working Travel | • Data Centre Migration DC Audit | • Can-Do Attitude |

CERTIFICATIONS & Professional Affiliations

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| • Certified PRINCE2 Practitioner Certified SCRUM Fundamental (SFC) | • Incident Response Expert & GRC Professional |
| • Certified Information Systems Auditor (CISA) | • Alibaba Cloud Computing (ACA) |
| • Certified ISMS ISO/IEC 27001-2013 Lead Auditor | • HPE, DELL & IBM Certified CompTIA Server+ DTECH (Cisco Technician) |
| • Certified Data Centre Management Professional (CDCMP) | • Certified Network Cabling Design Professional (CNCDP) |
| • Certified Telecommunications Project Management (CTPM) | • Information Systems Auditing, Controls and Assurance |

KEY TOOLS

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|---|--------------------|---|
| • JIRA, VISIO, Scrum, Kanban, Tableau, Python, UiPath | • OS Win / Linux | • ITSM: ServiceNow, Remedy, Cherwell, Mid-Range, Aperture |
| • MS Office (Word, Excel, PowerPoint), MS Project | • LAN/WAN/Wireless | • DCIM: 2bm, Sensorium, Asset Point, BMS, PAXTON |
| • Cisco, HPE ProLiant, IBM System X, Dell PowerEdge | • x86 Hardware | • Remote Access: ILO, iDRAC & IMM, Putty |

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE (CONTRACTS)

Senior Project Manager – Data Centre & Application Resilience | Active Growth Partners, United Kingdom | Jul 2024 – Present

- Leading end-to-end Data Centre Exit and IT Resilience programme delivery, ensuring compliant DR and BC plans across infrastructure and applications.
- Overseeing application's DR planning, and testing cycles, aligning RTO & RPO with business requirements and regulatory standards (e.g. ISO 22301, ISO 27001).
- Supporting cloud transformation projects, migrating legacy applications to enterprise-scale cloud environments (Azure, Active Directory, Virtualisation).
- Conducting Business Impact Analysis (BIA) and risk assessments to strengthen IT infrastructure resilience.
- Monitoring and ensuring third-party contracts align with resilience and compliance objectives.
- Driving continuous improvement in IT Resilience metrics, reporting, and governance frameworks.
- Provided PMO support, ensuring projects met deadlines, budgets, and strategic targets.
- Assessed data centres for resilience vulnerabilities and implemented mitigation strategies.

Infrastructure & Disaster Recovery Project Manager (Payments) | NatWest Group, United Kingdom | April 2022 – June 2024

- Aligned Digital Infrastructure across mobile and web platforms, ensuring seamless adaptations efficiently met global and local customer demands.
- Led infrastructure projects, ensuring compliance with agile and waterfall methods for stakeholder satisfaction from start to finish.
- Executed comprehensive discovery, assessment, and impact analyses to inform decision-making and strategic planning.
- Led the project as the first point of contact for technology resources, ensuring seamless communication within the project team.
- Oversaw lifecycle from design to support with comprehensive monitoring plans, maintaining comprehensive project plans for tracking.
- Proven track record of successfully managing multiple projects concurrently in a fast-paced environment.
- Presented project updates to C-suite executives with clear, concise PowerPoint and Tableau reports, facilitating informed decision-making.
- Utilised PMO subject matter experts to address resource management challenges.
- Led a team of project managers and analysts, providing guidance, coaching, and support to optimise project delivery while resolving conflicts.
- Managed project finances, forecasting, approvals, actuals, and risk/change management to ensure successful project outcomes within agreed budgets.
- Managed project lifecycle from HLD and LLD design to launch, enhancing payment system architecture from AS-IS to TO-BE for improved efficiency.
- Led project management workshops, steering committees, and stand-up meetings to promote teamwork, align our goals, integrate outcomes, and maintain clear communication with all stakeholders.
- Monitored projects from initiation (WBS, resource, budget) through delivery, ensuring alignment with project objectives and stakeholder expectations.
- Implemented Agile methodologies to increase project completion efficiency by 20% while maintaining a 98% on-time delivery rate.
- Facilitated cross-functional meetings with DevOps, Networks, Security, DB and firewall teams to address risks & enhance collaboration.
- Oversaw thorough testing procedures, covering both User Acceptance Testing (UAT) and Operational Acceptance Testing (OAT), to ensure everything matched project needs and the system was ready for smooth product launch and deployment.
- Oversaw the deployment of infrastructure changes into the live environment, managing post-go-live issues as they arose.
- Aligned project scope with business needs, ensured quality through testing and managed the test and production environments for efficient updates.
- Accountable for successfully transitioning projects into support, ensuring all service acceptance criteria were met.
- Streamlined third-party contracts & finances for smooth deliverables through joint vendor & team efforts.
- Used JMeter for test case development and execution, collaborated with developers to identify defects and refine test plans.
- Conducted thorough App evaluations, including performance testing, and meticulously documented results to uphold project governance standards.

- Optimized planning and execution for CAPEX and site delivery, managing order and inventory efficiently.
- Implemented and monitored comprehensive Disaster Recovery plans for critical digital applications, ensuring uninterrupted business continuity.
- Oversaw E-to-E Disaster Recovery testing initiatives, including planning, scheduling, resource allocation, risk management, and RTO/RPO reporting.
- Led the deployment of 1700 scanners across 1000 UK and Channel Islands sites, ensuring seamless integration with Panini/Fujitsu.
- Conducted 1000 site surveys to assess network port and wall power socket availability, health, and safety considerations for scanner deployments.
- Managed infrastructure operations, DNS, SSH, Certificates & CDBM tasks, utilizing ServiceNow for incident, change, and problem management.
- Collaborated with network teams to implement DDI solutions and configure firewall rules for secure communication between Apps and infrastructure.
- Worked with scanner vendors such as Panini and Fujitsu to facilitate hardware installations and resolve technical and Logistics issues as needed.
- Led team to streamline procedures, reducing resolution time by 20% across 1000 NatWest sites, enhancing technical skills in field engineers.
- Created break-fix documentation, overseeing incident resolution for faulty scanner requests by triaging issues and determining solutions.

Technical Project Manager | FINSTRAND LTD, United Kingdom | Jul 2021 – April 2022

- Led cloud migration projects within the insurance sector, ensuring seamless transitions and minimal disruption to operations.
- Orchestrated the Cloud Migration Discovery Phase, covering diverse scenarios and guiding a team through data collection from 168 sites.
- Developed comprehensive Discovery Assessment Reports and managed RAID for effective risk mitigation.
- Demonstrated technical leadership in architecting scalable solutions, achieving improvements, and ensuring on-time project completion.
- Proficiently executed cloud assessments, defined migration strategies, and ensuring precise documentation and timeline adherence.
- Facilitated seamless transitions to target cloud platforms, optimizing resources and fostering knowledge sharing.
- Managed LAN/WAN connectivity and efficiently resolved technical issues across diverse environments.
- Oversaw daily stand-ups and coordinated onshore/offshore teams across global time zones, showcasing robust project management expertise.
- Coordinated end-to-end site delivery for multiple projects, liaising with vendors, contractors, and internal teams for seamless execution.
- Analysed and reported on project financial performance, identifying areas for improvement and cost optimization.
- Assisted in the development and implementation of CAPEX planning and control processes.
- Managed end-to-end site delivery, coordinating cross-functional teams to ensure timely and cost-effective project completion, providing financial insights and recommendations to project teams, and liaising with vendors, contractors, and internal teams for seamless execution.
- Identified and mitigated financial risks, implementing measures to safeguard and ensure project profitability and sustainability.
- Collaborated with stakeholders to ensure alignment and effective decision-making for project success.

Technical Officer - Critical Facilities | Surrey County Council, United Kingdom | Mar 2021 - Jun 2021

- Managed diverse operational services within the Critical Facilities Group for the Data Centre.
- Oversaw product/version introductions/withdrawals, portfolio optimization, and cost/risk assessment.
- Ensured 100% availability of mechanical, electrical, and security infrastructure, meeting reporting requirements.
- Handled inquiries, resolved issues promptly, maintained service quality and oversaw contractors for SLA adherence.
- Ensured smooth day-to-day operations, utilizing advanced management tools and rigorous maintenance.
- Implemented capacity management, disaster recovery, and contingency planning while overseeing Tapes & Storage, Networking, Telco, Cabling, Power Distribution, and Cooling Systems.
- Provided strategic guidance for the design and implementation of Data Centre environments.
- Led incident processes covering backup, security, H&S, environmental compliance; led maintenance, installation, ensuring service compliance.
- Liaised with internal and external stakeholders, including managed services, suppliers, and partners.
- Identified industry best practices and optimized operational methods with third-party service providers.
- Provided 24/7 support for the Council's "Remote Hands" services.
- Oversees various management records: RAID, visitor, deliveries, access cards, CCTV, PAXTON, cabinet security, and plant checks.

Technical Project Consultant | CDW Limited, United Kingdom | Jan 2020 – Mar 2021

- Managed data centre projects, covering equipment installation, system configuration, and infrastructure optimization.
- Diagnosed and swiftly resolved technical issues, performed routine maintenance, and maintained vigilant system performance.
- Provided expert technical leadership, guiding colleagues through complex tasks.
- Improved data centre efficiency through assessments, upgrades, and optimizations.
- Served as a Technical Project Consultant, delivering support and change services across diverse clients and sites.
- Oversaw master plans, schedules, and priorities, ensuring 24/7 support operations met performance targets in multi-vendor cloud environments.
- Led end-to-end virtualization workstreams, from data capture to architectural assessments and implementation.
- Oversaw configuration, maintenance, upgrades, and diagnostics, ensuring SLA adherence.
- Handled parts logistics, addressing hardware issues and following the RAMs (Return Merchandise Authorization) procedure.
- Proactively managed client expectations through training and clear communication on resolution options, timelines, and budgets.
- Applied the CDW Risk framework to monitor project delivery, identify risks, and escalate as needed.
- Provided 24/7 monitoring and managed Data Centre escalations for seamless operations and rapid issue resolution.

Data Centre Operations & Capacity Management | Royal Bank of Scotland, United Kingdom | Oct 2015 - Dec 2019

- Spearheaded initiatives with budgets exceeding £100 million in Resilience and £10 million in Data Centre Exits, Migrations, and Consolidations.
- Ensure optimal performance, reliability, and resilience of Data Centres across the United Kingdom through day-to-day operations management.
- Manage 24/7 Data Centre incident resolution and documentation, including equipment inventory, maintenance schedules, and incident reports.
- Implemented resilience strategies to minimize downtime and ensure business continuity during disruptions.
- Led Data Centre consolidation, cutting costs by 20%, enhancing disaster recovery, and prioritizing RPO/RTO reporting for transparency.
- Orchestrated successfully migrating and decommissioning 15,000 IT assets, including 3,000 physical-to-virtual.
- Led virtualization, monitored hardware, and collaborated in Change Management, Platform Orchestration, and Security to prevent interruptions.
- Ensured stringent adherence to Data Centre standards and procedures, encompassing environmental and Physical access controls.
- Implemented monthly preventative maintenance procedures encompassing cooling, power, space, and connectivity, via DCIM and the BMS.

- Cultivated vendor relationships, managed procurement, negotiated contracts, & oversaw installations to ensure timely equipment & service delivery. Oversee and actively contribute to designing and implementing Data Centre expansion, infrastructure refreshes, upgrades, and IT patch deployments, collaborating closely for seamless execution.
- Remained abreast of industry trends and emerging technologies to improve DCIM practices continuously, informing decision-making processes.
- Led a Data Centre technician and Smart Hands teams, providing mentorship, training, and conducting performance evaluations.
- Directed space management operations across six UK Data Centres, including RBS-owned facilities, spearheading co-location initiatives for efficiency.
- Implemented strategic space planning frameworks to strategically allocate Data Centre space, minimizing unused rack space and optimizing the Data Centre footprint by 15%, thus enhancing operational efficiency.
- Conducted DC capacity monitoring post-installation, decommission, or migration using Asset Management tools to inform strategic planning efforts.
- Oversee regular audits to identify space constraints, assess capacity, and evaluate DC performance, implementing corrective actions promptly.
- Maintained detailed documentation of Data Centre layouts with Visio/AUTOCAD, implemented Data Centre health and safety standards, enforced cable management protocols, and monitored space utilization trends to support capacity planning.
- Supervised the design and execution of Data Centre expansion projects to accommodate growth and heightened demand.

Data Centre Project Engineer | HSBC, United Kingdom | Mar 2015 – Sep 2015

- Led and coordinated data centre projects, ensuring seamless deployment, maintenance, and optimization of x86 mid-range hardware across multiple sites while enhancing service quality and mitigating operational risks.
- Oversee data centre operations and governance, ensuring adherence to industry standards and best practices.
- Deploy Red Hat and Windows operating systems across the infrastructure, optimizing performance and reliability.
- Perform hardware troubleshooting to diagnose and resolve issues promptly, minimizing downtime.
- Collaborate with cross-functional teams to implement and support VMware solutions as needed.
- Conduct regular audits and assessments to ensure the integrity and security of data centre infrastructure.
- Oversaw high-integrity Data Centre operations delivery by developing and maintaining procedures and controls.
- Led the hands-on deployment of HP Proliant Series and IBM x3650 m4/x3850 servers across multiple HSBC application domains, including bonding network interfaces, verification of copper/fibre interfaces, and network link validation.
- Led group-wide service delivery via an ITIL-compliant service desk for server deployment and change control. Authored, modified, and executed Build Scripts for Windows and Red Hat Enterprise Linux OS. Collaborated for server installations and issue resolution.
- Maintained open communication with project teams to understand server infrastructure requirements. Represented Data Centre Operations in project meetings to discuss environment migration. Coordinated physical site surveys for project readiness and alignment.

Data Centre System Engineer & Project Engineer | Royal Bank of Scotland, United Kingdom | Jun 2006 – Mar 2015

- Swiftly respond to hardware failure alerts in the data centre, conducting thorough diagnostics with advanced tools to pinpoint issues on HP, Dell, and IBM servers, ensuring minimal downtime and optimal performance while collaborating closely with cross-functional teams to assess impact.
- Handled server provisioning, encompassing rack, stack, and configuration, in line with industry standards and client specifications.
- Planned and implemented the installation of new cabinets and free-standing equipment, ensuring optimal placement for efficiency and accessibility.
- Facilitated seamless server break-fix operations during Data Centre migrations by managing spare parts and coordinating purchase orders.
- Collaborated closely with migration and project teams to ensure timely delivery in line with stakeholder specifications.
- Oversaw new project orders, warranty, service levels, goods receipt, RMA process, and asset records management.
- Managed structured cabling infrastructure, ensuring quality and organization. Collaborated on network and storage needs with support teams. Leveraged data centre expertise to tackle challenges, aiding project success and post-merger transitions.
- Manage incoming calls and emails to the data centre support function, promptly addressing customer inquiries and issues.
- Collaborated with support teams for efficient technical assistance in live data centres. Coordinated with onsite engineers and managed Smart Hands support. Engaged third-party suppliers to report and escalate customer issues for timely resolution within SLAs.
- Implement proactive measures for updating customer systems and resolving service issues to maintain optimal data centre operations.
- Monitor escalated tickets to 2nd line support against agreed timescales, ensuring timely resolution and client satisfaction.
- Demonstrated leadership in Disaster Recovery Tests, power-down, and Patch events, ensuring smooth operations and protocol adherence.
- Follow escalation processes, including ticketing systems, to escalate issues to support management and other teams as necessary.
- Conducted rigorous testing and executed proactive maintenance to validate hardware, prevent failures, and ensure system functionality.
- Managed asset registers for equipment across five Data Centres, ensuring accurate inventory records for Data Centre Auditing.
- Maintained spare parts inventory, recorded incidents, led IT projects, and stayed updated with emerging technologies and industry best practices.
- Coordinated and supervised third-party break-fix activities, ensuring prompt maintenance response and adherence to company standards.
- Managed 24/7 monitoring and Data Centre escalations for seamless operations and problem-solving.

Additional Experiences:

- **Data Centre & Desktop IMAC Engineer** at Barclays Capital, Deutsche Bank, Morgan Stanley, Credit Suisse, BNP Paribas, State Street, MAN Investment, Surrey County Council, RBS, Goldman Sachs, JP Morgan & Chase, Citi Group, Scottish Power etc.
- **Co-Locations** at Infinity, Colt, Digital Realty, Global Switch, Equinix, IOmart, 6 Degree, Cyxtera

Education & Credentials

- Master of Strategic Management - via L7 Diploma Extension – United Kingdom 2018 - 2020
- Bachelor of Commerce – University of Karachi – Pakistan - 2000 - 2002
- National Diploma in Computer Studies - United Kingdom – 1998 - 2000

References

Available upon request.